

most basic needs are at the base: physiological needs like food, water, and shelter. Above that come the needs that aren't tangible but are still deemed essential: Safety needs like health, employment, and physical security. The third and fourth levels are psychological needs like love and a sense of belonging, followed by self-esteem. This is where society starts to mistake needs for wants. And at the tippy-top is the need that generally gets taken for granted: self-fulfillment, the feeling that you are meeting your full potential. Maslow's theory says that lower-level basic needs must be met before we can pursue higher-level needs. It's why so much of the conversation around spending money is confined to tangible stuff. But once we meet those lower-level basic needs, and even if they're not met 100 percent, our brains move on to wanting to achieve the higher-level needs, no matter how limited our income. I don't know about you, but there have been many times I've "overspent" my budget to buy a self-help book or because a friend wanted to get dinner. It wasn't because I needed the book or the dinner—my basic needs had been met. I was pursuing higher-level needs.

And suppressing our higher-level, internal needs can cost us more than money. We all know people who've stayed in bad relationships because they don't know their worth and people-pleasers who overextend themselves.

For at least the last one hundred years, we've been told that our worth as a person is tied to how many physical and safety needs we can accumulate. As a result, we are very blatantly judged by, and spend more on, our home, cars, vacations, and how "healthy" we look while neglecting things like relationships and self-fulfillment.

It's not ideal, but the other extreme isn't the answer either. People who pursue a sense of belonging and self-actualization above foundational needs won't get what they want unless what they want is to end up in a cult documentary on HBO.

So, in your quest to figure out what you love, know that your first loves probably aren't things per se, but more like needs, both external and internal. And similar to Maslow's triangle, what you love won't be linear but more of a hierarchy. Because you can't find purpose on an empty stomach.